Zerodha Coin SIP case: interview notes

Nov 1, 2026

How to run each interview

Each interview takes about 40 minutes. Fill in that person's table during or right after the call, then the summary grid at the end. Use P1 to P6 instead of names everywhere in this doc.

Opening script (read out)

> Thanks for doing this. I'm working on a student product case about how people's first SIP goes in its first year. There are no right or wrong answers, and I'm not selling anything or giving investment advice. I won't ask for your PAN, account numbers, fund names or screenshots. Is it OK if I take notes? You can skip any question.

Rules

- Ask what happened, not what they would do. "Tell me about the last time" works better than "Would you ever".
- Don't mention failed payments or returns before they do. Questions 7 and 12 are written so they can bring them up first.
- If they ask which fund to pick, say it's outside this conversation.
- Write their own words in the quotes column whenever something sounds important.

The questions (second version)

These questions get people to tell stories, show you things and react to rough ideas, rather than repeat their survey answers. A full interview takes about 40 minutes. If time is short, ask only the starred ones. Each question says why a growth PM would ask it.

A. The story (10 min)

1. ★ Let's draw a timeline of your SIP, from the first time you thought about investing until today. What was going on in your life when you first thought "I should start"?
    - *Why:* real triggers (first salary, a friend, a goal) show when to reach new investors, and what promise they bought into.
2. What else could that money have gone to: an FD, an RD, a gadget, stocks? What made the SIP win?
    - *Why:* this is the SIP's real competition. When people stop, the money flows back to one of these.

3. When did it first feel real, the moment you thought “okay, this is working”?
    - *Why:* the activation moment. If nobody can name one, Coin never gave them a moment worth staying for.

B. Money in their head (8 min)

4. ★ Walk me through salary day. Your salary lands: where does it go over the next week, in what order?
    - *Why:* shows whether the SIP is paid first or fights rent and EMIs for what's left. That is the root of short-balance failures.
5. If one month you were ₹5,000 short, what would you cut first? Where does the SIP sit on that list?
    - *Why:* tells us whether a “skip one month” or “reduce for now” option would save the SIP or only delay a stop.
6. Do you think of your SIP as savings, a bill, or something else?
    - *Why:* a bill gets paid without thinking; savings get dipped into. The framing changes how a failure feels.

C. The failure moment (10 min)

7. ★ Tell me about the last time something about your SIP surprised you, good or bad.
    - *Why:* lets failures come up without naming them, unlike the survey's direct question.
8. ★ If something went wrong: take me through that day like a film. Where were you, what did you see first, what did you do in the next ten minutes, and the next day?
    - *Why:* remembered steps beat opinions. Every pause in the story is friction a product can remove.
9. Who or what did you turn to: support, Google, YouTube, a friend? What did they tell you?
    - *Why:* the discovery engine found 112 posts asking forums for help. Where people go for help is where a fix must reach them.
10. ★ Without sharing your screen, open your app now and find where you'd check whether this month's instalment went through. Tell me what you see and what you'd tap.
    - *Why:* a live usability check that never shows their holdings. If they can't find the status, failures stay silent.
11. Which bank account is your mandate on, and do you know its limit? What would happen to your SIP if you changed bank or UPI app?
    - *Why:* tests the mental model behind silent failures. On Coin, a new bank needs a new mandate.

D. Expectations and stopping (8 min)

12. ★ When you started, what number did you have in your head, for returns or for what the SIP would grow to? Where did that number come from?
    - *Why:* finds the anchor and its source (a calculator, a friend, an ad). Tests the returns option without suggesting returns were bad.
13. At what point would you call your SIP "not working"?
    - *Why:* their own line for failure. If it's about payments, that points to recovery; if it's about returns, to expectations.
14. ★ Only if they stopped or paused: tell me about the day you stopped. What happened just before you tapped stop? Where did that money go the next month?
    - *Why:* the order of events decides between the two problem statements, and where the money went shows the competitor.
15. Did you think about pausing or lowering the amount instead? Why or why not?
    - *Why:* shows whether pausing is unknown, distrusted or just hard to find.

E. Reactions to rough ideas (5 min)

Read each one aloud, then ask: "What would you do if you saw this? What would annoy you?" They are made up for the interview; none recommends a fund or uses fear or urgency.

- **C1, before the date:** "Your ₹3,000 SIP is due on the 5th. Your salary usually arrives on the 7th. Move your SIP date to the 8th?"
- **C2, after a failure:** "This month's ₹3,000 instalment didn't go through because your autopay limit was reached. Pay it now, or skip this month and keep your SIP running."
- **C3, on progress:** "In the first year, SIP values often move up and down. Here's what you've put in so far, month by month."
- **C4, ★ the choice:** "If only one of these existed, which would you keep, and why?"
    - *Why:* a cheap test of what people want before building anything. Their pick tells Part 5 what to build first.

F. Close (3 min)

16. What would a friend starting their first SIP on Coin need to know that nobody told you?
    - *Why:* surfaces set-up and expectation gaps in their own words, ready to use as in-app text.
17. Would you try an early version of a fix in a couple of weeks?
    - *Why:* recruits testers for Part 6.

P1: sheet row 34

Zerodha user. Picked because an instalment failed from a mandate problem and they found out over a week later. Date of call:

Rows marked “Old” came from the first question set; they cover new questions 1, 4 and 12, and part of 11. The rows after them use the new numbering.

#	Question	What they said	Their words
Old 1	Why they started	everyone telling me its a good investment, and to stop my unnecessary expenditure	
Old 2	What they expected in year one	nothing, not much gain expected	
Old 3	Setting it up	yes	
Old 4	How money moves each month	bank mandate	
Old 5	SIP date vs salary date	salary-1st day of the month, SIP date-5th of the month so that their is sufficient balance to pay for my SIP	
2	What else the money could have gone to	just wanted to try, the advertisment made me do it.	
3	When it felt real	never	
4	Salary day	pay bills, then EMIS, then SIP	
5	What gets cut first	SIP	
6	Savings or a bill	savings	
7	Last surprise	when i checked 15 months after investing, it was the same amount as initial .	

#	Question	What they said	Their words
8	The day it went wrong, step by step	mandate payment got failed , i didn't got to know the same day as i was travelling where there was network , i returned in the network area after two days then saw that the payment was not carried out	
9	Who they turned to	support, to mail , not resolved	
10	App check: finding instalment status		
11 12	Mandate: bank, limit, changing bank The number in their head, and its source	ICICI Bank, 5000 limit and i dont know what will happen if I change my bank double	
13	When it's "not working"	returns	
14	The day they stopped; where the money went	not stopped	
15	Pause or reduce instead	never thought about it	
C1	Reaction: move the date	yes will move the date	
C2	Reaction: pay now or skip	skip this month	
C3	Reaction: month-by-month view	3000 every month	
C4	Which one they'd keep		
16	Advice for a friend	selection of funds, which funds to invest in nobody told me that	
17	Open to testing a fix	yes	

P2: sheet row 27

Zerodha user. Picked because they weren't sure whether an instalment failed, named a mandate problem and found out over a week later. Date of call:

#	Question	What they said	Their words
1	How they came to start	got to know from a friend, started 2018	
2	What else the money could have gone to	to stop the unnecessary expenditure	
3	When it felt real	never	
4	Salary day, in order	SIP is fixed at 5th of every month	
5	What gets cut first	never gets short of money	
6	Savings or a bill	savings	
7	Last surprise	got good returns from one mutual fund SIP, earler invested 2000 rs now its value is 8000 rs	
8	The day it went wrong, step by step	one time my SIP failed on the due date, the day it should have been successfully executed	
9	Who they turned to	support ticket , zerodha revealed there has been a glitch lay with their payment processor, not resolved, missed the investment window.	
10	App check: finding instalment status		
11	Mandate: bank, limit, changing bank	pay manually and bank mandate, changed bank, requested from zerodha App to change bank but no problem faced in changing bank	
12	The number in their head, and its source	double in 3 years	
13	When it's "not working"	less than 10 % returns	
14	The day they stopped; where the money went	if not got more than 10 % returns in one year then stopped the SIP	
15	Pause or reduce instead	never lowered only increased , never paused	
C1	Reaction: move the date	yes	

#	Question	What they said	Their words
C2	Reaction: pay now or skip	pay it now	
C3	Reaction: month-by-month view		
C4	Which one they'd keep		
16	Advice for a friend	direct and regular investment , go for direct because commission is cut and always go for growth, I use value research app , but not got that from zerodha	
17	Open to testing a fix	yes	

P3: sheet row 2

Zerodha user. Picked because they started recently and already had a failed instalment. Some survey answers conflict, so check when they really started. Date of call:

#	Question	What they said	Their words
1	How they came to start	influenced from social media , to invest and get returns from mutual funds and SIPs	
2	What else the money could have gone to	diversify the portfolio, RD and stocks , chose SIP because if it gives better returns	
3	When it felt real	initial and post COVID it felt real and i took a good decision	
4	Salary day, in order	5th of every month , auto mandate	
5	What gets cut first	will not get cut	
6	Savings or a bill	savings	
7	Last surprise	Quant tax savings mutual funds invested 20K, but now its value is 50K	

#	Question	What they said	Their words
8	The day it went wrong, step by step	2024 SIP failed due to bank error , their was some issue with my debit card and i didn't got to know about that mail and 3 months SIPs was unpaid due to this	
9	Who they turned to	only visible on website not on app , used support and then resolved it	
10	App check: finding instalment status		
11	Mandate: bank, limit, changing bank	bank mandate	
12	The number in their head, and its source	double	
13	When it's "not working"	expectations, kotak mutual funds went to negative in 6 months	
14	The day they stopped; where the money went	and stopped the kotak mutual fund that day, and then the money was used in the already invested mutual funds made the amount higher.	
15	Pause or reduce instead	no as trend line went much down in only 6 months	
C1	Reaction: move the date	move the date	
C2	Reaction: pay now or skip	skip	
C3	Reaction: month-by-month view		
C4	Which one they'd keep		
16	Advice for a friend	UI is a bit complex so dont suggest it to an early investor.	
17	Open to testing a fix	yes	

P4: sheet row 8

Zerodha user. Picked as the comparison: started 13–24 months ago, still running, no problems reported. Date of call:

#	Question	What they said	Their words
1	How they came to start	when started earning	
2	What else the money could have gone to	use in stocks	
3	When it felt real	after 2-3 months i saw the compounding effect in unrealised PNL	
4	Salary day, in order	Auto pay set	
5	What gets cut first	expenses not SIP	
6	Savings or a bill	savings	
7	Last surprise	during trump oil crisis , market was not stable	
8	The day it went wrong, step by step	due to app problem, auto pay was not carried out	
9	Who they turned to	manually resolved it	
10	App check: finding instalment status		
11	Mandate: bank, limit, changing bank	bank mandate	
12	The number in their head, and its source	goal was closed ended fund , as risk was low and returns are more as entry and exit load are less	
13	When it's "not working"	if risk increases , will then diversify the portfolio	
14	The day they stopped; where the money went	in a different mutual fund	
15	Pause or reduce instead	never thought	
C1	Reaction: move the date	move the date	

#	Question	What they said	Their words
C2	Reaction: pay now or skip	pay now	
C3	Reaction: month-by-month view		
C4	Which one they'd keep		
16	Advice for a friend	go for direct plans on Coin, as expense ratio is less	
17	Open to testing a fix	yes	

P5: sheet row 5

Uses another app. Picked because they stopped their SIP after an instalment failed on a short balance. Date of call:

#	Question	What they said	Their words
1	How they came to start	when i had surplus money	
2	What else the money could have gone to	would have spent it	
3	When it felt real	because of investment i was assured i could afford a career switch	
4	Salary day, in order	first pay sip manually, then pay bills	
5	What gets cut first	not cut sip	
6	Savings or a bill	savings	
7	Last surprise	mutual fund went down due to global events and post COVID 2 years were good but not now	
8	The day it went wrong, step by step	Payment was not completed, it was still in process but was notified the payment was successful	
9	Who they turned to	support	
10	App check: finding instalment status		

#	Question	What they said	Their words
11	Mandate: bank, limit, changing bank	manually pay , never changed bank	
12	The number in their head, and its source	returns were good at the time i started	
13	When it's "not working"	when returns are worst than expected like my icici prudential mutual fund last year returns -were 12 % but this year returns -7%	
14	The day they stopped; where the money went	one sip- sbi automative SIP -did one time investment but not much returns were coming so i paused it	
15	Pause or reduce instead	paused it	
C1	Reaction: move the date	move the date	
C2	Reaction: pay now or skip	pay it now	
C3	Reaction: month-by-month view		
C4	Which one they'd keep		
16	Advice for a friend	use only 1 platform , as its hard to maintain	
17	Open to testing a fix	yes	

P6: sheet row 13

Uses another app. Picked because they stopped their SIP, didn't know pausing existed, and weren't investing at the 1-year mark. Date of call:

#	Question	What they said	Their words
1	How they came to start	when i started earning	
2	What else the money could have gone to	i would have invested them in stocks	
3	When it felt real	post COVID when the returns were high	

#	Question	What they said	Their words
4	Salary day, in order	pay bills, EMIs, then SIP	
5	What gets cut first	SIP	
6	Savings or a bill	savings	
7	Last surprise	Post COVID , around 2023, one of my mutual fund SIP returns were over 12% the initial amount. Second surprise: when they started as a new user, Zerodha didn't move them to direct plans at first, first regular plans were offered. They only noticed long after. (See the note under this table.)	
8	The day it went wrong, step by step	portfolio was not updated at real time- it was stuck on yesterday's NAV , checked via different app it was different.	
9	Who they turned to	support	
10	App check: finding instalment status		
11	Mandate: bank, limit, changing bank	mandate, not changed banks	
12	The number in their head, and its source	double in 2 years	
13	When it's "not working"	payments are not recovering and expectations too not met	
14	The day they stopped; where the money went	stopped as there were frequently issues going on with portfolio updates and auto pay issues	
15	Pause or reduce instead	paused one of the SIPs	
C1	Reaction: move the date	move the date	
C2	Reaction: pay now or skip	skip	
C3	Reaction: month-by-month view		

#	Question	What they said	Their words
C4	Which one they'd keep		
16	Advice for a friend	use a different app for now, zerodha is a bit complex to understand at first	
17	Open to testing a fix	yes	

Note on row 7, checked 5 Nov 2026. The SEBI change runs the other way. From 1 November 2026, direct plans are the default choice on fund houses' (AMCs') own websites and apps. Regular plans stay available, with their higher expense ratio shown (Cafemutual). It was announced by the SEBI chairman on 28 October; no circular had been published by 30 October, and it doesn't cover broker apps like Coin or move anyone to regular plans (INDmoney). Coin sells direct funds with no commission (Zerodha). Regular-plan units moved into Zerodha from elsewhere stay regular; switching means redeeming them and buying the direct plan, which can be taxed (Zerodha). Open question for P6: where were the regular-plan units first bought?

Summary grid

After each call, pick Yes, No or Unclear in that person's column. Leave a cell empty if it didn't come up. This grid is what decides between the two problem statements.

What to confirm	P1	P2	P3	P4	P5	P6
An instalment failed at some point	▾	▾	▾	▾	▾	▾
Found out more than a week later	▾	▾	▾	▾	▾	▾
Recovering was hard or unclear	▾	▾	▾	▾	▾	▾
A failure came before stopping or pausing	▾	▾	▾	▾	▾	▾
Would have kept going if fixed within a day	▾	▾	▾	▾	▾	▾
Returns fell short of what they expected	▾	▾	▾	▾	▾	▾
Stopped or paused because of returns	▾	▾	▾	▾	▾	▾
Knew they could pause	▾	▾	▾	▾	▾	▾

How it decides. If rows 1, 2 and 4 are mostly Yes, the recovery statement stands. If rows 6 and 7 are mostly Yes and row 4 mostly No, switch to the returns statement. A mix keeps both, with recovery leading.